Cruise Ship Pianist Rescued After Nine Hours in the Pacific

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Two fishermen off the coast of California spotted something surprising in the water about 20 miles from shore: a man, **treading** water, all alone in the Pacific Ocean. 'Yeah, it's a human being. Stop the boat,' Garrett recalled saying. The man told them he was a **pianist** on the Ovation of the Seas, a big cruise ship. He had been in the water for about nine hours. 'The only thing he said to me was, 'Thank you. I thought I was gonna die,'' Norton said. The fishermen pulled him from the water and called for help. The Coast Guard and **lifeguards** took over, and confirmed he worked on the ship. Norton said the man was lucky in one big way: the ocean was unusually warm. The water was 76 degrees **Fahrenheit**. 'You have this crazy super **El Niño** year,' Norton said. 'A different year, no way he makes it.' How the **pianist** ended up in the water is not clear. Two fishermen in the right place at the right time, and a very warm ocean, helped save his life.

Word Treasure

treading -- Staying afloat in water by moving your arms and legs.
pianist -- A person who plays the piano.
lifeguards -- Trained people who rescue swimmers in trouble in the water.
Fahrenheit -- A way of measuring how hot or cold something is, used in the United States.
El Niño -- A weather pattern that warms the waters of the Pacific Ocean.

Background you need

A cruise ship is a very big ship that carries people on holiday.

Treading water means staying afloat by moving your arms and legs.

Lifeguards and the Coast Guard are trained rescuers who help people in trouble in the sea.

Break it down

WHO: Two fishermen, a cruise ship pianist, the Coast Guard and lifeguards.
WHAT: The fishermen rescued a man who had spent nine hours treading water in the Pacific.
WHERE: About 20 miles off the coast of California.
WHY: The ocean was unusually warm, which helped him survive.

Why it matters

If you ever go swimming in the sea, this story shows why warm water, luck and kind strangers can matter so much.

Test what you remember

1. Who spotted the man in the water?

(A) A cruise ship captain
(B) Two fishermen
(C) The Coast Guard
(D) A helicopter crew

2. How far from shore was he?

(A) About 2 miles
(B) About 20 miles
(C) About 200 miles
(D) About 2,000 miles

3. How long had he been in the water?

(A) About nine hours
(B) About nine days
(C) About nine minutes
(D) About nine weeks

4. What was the man's job?

(A) A pianist on the Ovation of the Seas
(B) A Coast Guard officer
(C) A fisherman
(D) A lifeguard

5. What did the man say to Norton?

(A) 'Thank you. I thought I was gonna die.'
(B) 'I am very cold.'
(C) 'Please take me home.'
(D) 'Where is my ship?'

6. Why did the warm water matter?

(A) It made the fish bite more
(B) It helped him survive nine hours in the sea
(C) It pushed him toward shore
(D) It made the boat faster

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: A 4: A 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Fisherman Sean Norton: He says the man was lucky because the ocean was unusually warm, and that in a different year he would not have made it.

2. The cruise line: It says it will share no further details, to respect the privacy of its employee.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):